

Installing Git and GitHub Desktop

A step-by-step setup guide for Windows and Mac

Overview: Git is the version-control tool that tracks changes to your code. GitHub Desktop lets you use Git through an interface instead of typing commands, and it connects directly to your GitHub account. This guide installs Git first, then GitHub Desktop, then does first-time setup for both. Wherever a step involves typing a command, the Windows and Mac versions are shown side by side. Note that you only need Git or GitHub Desktop.

Part A: Installing Git

A1. Download the installer

Windows	Mac
Go to git-scm.com/download/win — the download starts automatically.	Go to git-scm.com/download/mac and click the link to download the latest installer (a .dmg file).

A2. Run the installer

Windows	Mac
Open the downloaded .exe file, click Yes to allow it, then click through the setup wizard. The default options are fine for nearly everyone (see note below on two settings worth checking).	Open the downloaded .dmg file, then double-click the .pkg installer inside it and follow the prompts (Continue → Agree → Install). You may need to enter your Mac login password.

Windows-specific setting: In the Windows wizard, two screens are worth a second look: “Adjusting your PATH environment” — keep the recommended default so git works from any terminal, not just Git Bash; and “Choosing the default editor” — switch this to Notepad if you're not familiar with Vim.

A3. Alternative: install with a package manager

If you already use a package manager, this is a faster route than downloading an installer:

Windows	Mac
<code>winget install --id Git.Git -e --source winget</code>	<code>brew install git</code>

Mac alternative you may see automatically: On a Mac, if you run a git command in Terminal before installing anything and macOS has never asked before, you may see a system prompt to install the “Xcode Command Line Tools” instead. Clicking Install there is a valid, lighter-weight way to get Git — you don't need to also run the steps above.

A4. Verify the installation

Windows	Mac
Open the Start menu, type Git Bash, press Enter, then run:	Open Terminal (Applications → Utilities → Terminal, or search with Spotlight), then run:
<code>git --version</code>	<code>git --version</code>

Both should print a version number (e.g. git version 2.4x.x). If you get “command not found” / “not recognized”, close and reopen the terminal window — a fresh window is sometimes needed to pick up the updated PATH.

Part B: Installing GitHub Desktop

B1. Download

Windows	Mac
Go to desktop.github.com and click Download for Windows (64bit).	Go to desktop.github.com and click Download for Apple silicon (M1/M2/M3/M4 Macs) or Download for Mac with Intel chip (check Apple menu → About This Mac if unsure).

B2. Install and launch

Windows	Mac
Open the downloaded installer file. It installs and launches automatically — there's no multi-step wizard to click through.	Open the downloaded .zip file, which unzips into a GitHub Desktop application. Double-click it to launch. If macOS warns the app was downloaded from the internet, click Open to confirm.

Part C: First-time setup

C1. Sign in to GitHub Desktop

This step is identical on both platforms:

1. When GitHub Desktop opens for the first time, click Sign in to GitHub.com.
2. Your browser opens and asks you to authorise GitHub Desktop — sign in with your GitHub account and click Authorise.
3. Switch back to GitHub Desktop, which should now show you signed in.

C2. Set your Git identity

Git labels every change with a name and email. GitHub Desktop usually prompts for this on first launch, but you can also set it directly from a terminal. The commands themselves are identical on both platforms — only the terminal you type them into differs:

Windows	Mac
Terminal: Git Bash (or Command Prompt / PowerShell)	Terminal: Terminal app
<code>git config --global user.name "Your Name"</code>	<code>git config --global user.name "Your Name"</code>
<code>git config --global user.email "you@example.com"</code>	<code>git config --global user.email "you@example.com"</code>

Use the same email address as your GitHub account (your LSE email, if that's what you signed up with) so your commits are correctly linked to your profile.

Alternatively, you can also go to *File > Options > Accounts* on Windows, or *GitHub Desktop > Preferences > Accounts* on Mac to log in to your account. Afterwards, go to *File > Options > Git* on Windows, or *GitHub Desktop > Preferences > Git* and add your *Name* and *Email* that correspond to your GitHub account.

C3. Test everything works: clone a repository

This step is also identical on both platforms:

1. In GitHub Desktop, click *File* → *Clone repository*.
2. Choose any repository you have access to, or create a new test repository first via the + button → *Create a New Repository*.
3. Choose a local folder to save it to, then click *Clone*.
4. The repository should open in GitHub Desktop's main window, showing its files and history — confirming Git, GitHub Desktop and your GitHub account are all correctly connected.

Troubleshooting

OS	Symptom	What to do
Windows	"git is not recognised" in Command Prompt/PowerShell	Close and reopen the terminal window — PATH changes only apply to new windows. If it still fails, re-run the Git installer and confirm the PATH option was set to add Git to the command line.
Both	Installer blocked, or asks for an administrator password you don't have	Likely an LSE-managed device restriction. Use a personal laptop, or contact LSE IT Services to request installation or admin rights.
Mac	macOS prompts to install "Command Line Tools" instead of opening your downloaded installer	This is expected and fine — click <i>Install</i> . It provides Git without needing the git-scm.com download.
Mac	macOS says the app "cannot be opened because it is from an unidentified developer"	Right-click (or Control-click) the GitHub Desktop app and choose <i>Open</i> , then confirm <i>Open</i> in the dialog. You only need to do this once.

OS	Symptom	What to do
Both	Browser doesn't return you to GitHub Desktop after "Authorise"	Make sure you're signed into the correct GitHub account in your browser. Close the browser tab and click Sign in to GitHub.com again in GitHub Desktop.
Both	Commits show the wrong name/email, or show as "unverified" on GitHub	Re-run the git config --global commands in Section C2 with the exact email address registered to your GitHub account, then make a new commit — past commits keep the old identity.